

Korea Daily Brief

Saturday, September 26, 2026

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RE: New Russian ambassador arrives Pyongyang · DMZ mine blast probe enters DMZ · NK crypto haul tops \$1B · Kim invited to Moscow

KOSPI
7,080.92
▲ +0.9%

USD/KRW
1,354.40
▼ -0.9%

BRENT
\$104.32
▼ -2.1%

BOK RATE
2.50%
Sep 2026

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Russia's new ambassador Andrei Podelyshev arrived in Pyongyang on Sep 26, nearly 10 months after his predecessor died in post, immediately visiting a memorial to DPRK troops killed in Kursk.
- 2 ROK Joint Chiefs and UNC Military Armistice Commission entered the DMZ five days after the Sep 21 land-mine blast to assess routes and communications ahead of a joint investigation set for Sep 27.
- 3 North Korean cybercriminals have now stolen more than \$1 billion in cryptocurrency in 2026, with the \$352 million Bitget heist pushing the annual haul past that threshold, per Bloomberg.

• TOP STORIES

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

New Russian ambassador Andrei Podelyshev arrives in Pyongyang, vows to maximize bilateral cooperation

Andrei Podelyshev arrived in Pyongyang on Sep 26 aboard a direct Nordwind flight from Moscow with his wife, nearly 10 months after his predecessor died in post — the cause of death was never officially announced by either side. Podelyshev immediately visited the Liberation Tower to honor Soviet soldiers killed in 1945, and separately paid respects to North Korean troops killed fighting in Kursk, and toured the 'Memorial Hall of Combat Feats of Overseas Military Operations.' He told TASS his mission is to 'activate practical cooperation' and 'make maximum use of the enormous potential' of bilateral ties, attributing the relationship's current high level to Putin and Kim Jong Un personally.

NK News · Yonhap English · 뉴스|스

US-KOREA

ROK military and UNC enter DMZ five days after land-mine blast to prepare joint investigation

The Joint Chiefs of Staff and UNC Military Armistice Commission conducted a preliminary DMZ reconnaissance on Sep 26, five days after a suspected land-mine detonation wounded three soldiers — two seriously — in an area south of the Military Demarcation Line in Paju, Gyeonggi Province on Sep 21. JCS Vice Chairman Gen. Kwon Dae-won led the approximately 20-person team, which assessed route safety, surveillance, and communications without entering the blast site itself. Opposition lawmaker **Han Dong-hoon** held a press conference at the Defense Ministry alleging the ROK government refused UNC Commander Gen. Xavier Brunson's request for immediate access on Sep 22, delaying the formal joint investigation to Sep 27 or later.

뉴시스 · 동아일보 · 경향신문

DPRK

North Korean crypto theft in 2026 surpasses \$1 billion after \$352M Bitget heist

The Bitget cryptocurrency exchange hack — attributed by the exchange's CEO to North Korean cybercriminals — stole *\$351.6 million* in digital assets from the Seychelles-based platform's internet-connected hot wallets, Bloomberg reports, pushing Pyongyang's 2026 crypto haul past \$1 billion. NK Pro had separately confirmed the Bitget link to DPRK actors. North Korean cyber operations fund weapons procurement and circumvent UN sanctions; the UN Panel of Experts previously assessed DPRK cyber theft as a primary sanctions evasion mechanism.

Bloomberg · NK Pro

• OVERNIGHT

DPRK KCNA: South Korea will become target of 'collective punishment' if it becomes US collective defence hub · Reuters

Escalatory warning; follows Sep 25 KCNA threat language.

DPRK KCNA: North Korea rejects call to halt nuclear tests · Reuters

Blanket rejection; FM Choe Son Hui declared nuclear irreversibility Sep 24.

DPRK 38 North: Kim Yo Jong's Paektu authority normalizes path for Kim Ju Ae succession · 38 North

Analysis frames Ju Ae's public appearances as mediated through Yo Jong's precedent.

US-KOREA ROK presidential office reaffirms humanitarian handling of two North Korean POWs transferred from Ukraine · Yonhap English

Statement responds to opposition pressure over undisclosed transfer.

US-KOREA President Lee calls for resumption of ROK-Mexico trade pact talks, cites 28 trillion won bilateral trade · Yonhap English

Lee proposed three cooperation pillars at Mexico City business forum on Sep 25.

DPRK Satellite imagery: North Korea building new warships at both Nampho and Chongjin shipyards since July · NK News / NK Pro

Dual-coast concurrent construction; Chongjin and Nampho both active.

\$1B+

NK crypto theft total in 2026 after Bitget heist

The \$352 million Bitget hack — attributed to North Korean cybercriminals by the exchange's CEO — pushed the DPRK's 2026 cryptocurrency haul past \$1 billion, per Bloomberg.

Bloomberg — Bitget Hack Pushes North Korean Crypto Haul Past \$1 Billion

PYONGYANG WATCH · KCNA

KIM JONG UN

WATCH FLAG

● No appearance (4d since last)

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

1. North Korea says South Korea will become target of 'collective punishment' if it becomes US collective defence hub

KCNA issued an explicit collective-punishment threat against South Korea, escalating from the previous day's warning language in a pattern of simultaneous kinetic and rhetorical escalation this week. — KCNA (Reuters)

2. North Korea rejects call to halt nuclear tests

KCNA issued a blanket rejection of international calls to halt nuclear testing, pairing with FM Choe Son Hui's Sep 24 irreversibility declaration to reinforce Pyongyang's dual-track diplomatic and nuclear escalation. — KCNA (Reuters)

3. Moscow invites North Korean leader Kim Jong Un for official visit

Russia's Deputy FM Andrei Rudenko officially confirmed via TASS that Kim Jong Un has been invited to visit Russia, with the schedule to be coordinated through diplomatic channels — issued the same day Russia's new ambassador arrived in Pyongyang. — KCNA (Kim stmt)

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Kim Yo Jong · Director, DPRK Propaganda and Agitation Department / Kim Jong Un's sister

38 North analysis (Sep 25, carried forward) examines Kim Yo Jong's consolidation of Paektu bloodline authority as a mechanism normalizing the path for Kim Ju Ae's eventual formal political role.

Bottom line: KCNA's dual output today — explicit 'collective punishment' threat against South Korea and blanket nuclear test halt rejection — sustains the escalatory kinetic-diplomatic sequencing of the past week. Watch for Punggye-ri seismic activity and Kim Jong Un's next confirmed public appearance (last confirmed Sep 22, now 4 days ago).

국방부 / 합동참모본부 · MINISTRY OF NATIONAL DEFENSE / JOINT CHIEFS OF STAFF

ROK military and UNC MAC enter DMZ five days after land-mine blast to prepare joint investigation

Gen. Kwon Dae-won (JCS Vice Chairman, TF lead)

The JCS and UNC Military Armistice Commission conducted a preliminary reconnaissance of the DMZ on Sep 26, assessing route safety, surveillance, and communications ahead of the formal joint investigation. Approximately 20 personnel participated, including the JCS Vice Chairman leading the joint investigation TF and the MAC Secretary; some soldiers present at the Sep 21 blast voluntarily joined.

[Primary](#) 뉴스스 ↗

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Presidential office reaffirms humanitarian handling of North Korean POWs from Ukraine

Presidential Office spokesperson

The presidential office reiterated its position on the two North Korean POWs transferred from Ukraine to South Korea, emphasizing the ROK government's commitment to humanitarian treatment. The statement came amid opposition party criticism that the transfer was not disclosed to the public in advance.

[Primary](#) Yonhap EN ↗

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

President Lee calls for resumption of ROK-Mexico trade pact negotiations at Mexico City business forum

President Lee Jae-myung

President **Lee Jae-myung** attended the Korea-Mexico Business Forum in Mexico City on Sep 25, proposing the two countries resume comprehensive trade agreement negotiations and deepen cooperation in investment, advanced industries, supply chains, future industries, energy, and cultural-creative sectors. Mexico is South Korea's largest Latin American trade and investment partner with bilateral trade reaching approximately 28 trillion won.

[Primary](#) Yonhap EN ↗

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Andrei Podelyshev **APPOINTED**

Russian Ambassador to North Korea

Podelyshev arrived in Pyongyang on Sep 26 aboard a direct Nordwind flight, filling the post left vacant since predecessor Alexander Matsegora died in December 2025. He is a career diplomat with prior assignments at the Soviet embassy in Pyongyang (1980s) and the Russian embassy in Seoul (1991-1996).

Replaces: Alexander Matsegora

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

PPP defense committee members demand emergency hearing on DMZ land-mine blast; DP planning Sep 28 site visit

National Defense Committee

PPP National Defense Committee members held a press conference at the National Assembly on Sep 26 demanding the defense minister and JCS chairman appear before a full committee hearing on the Sep 21 DMZ blast, the delay in the joint investigation, and undisclosed return of two North Korean POWs from Ukraine. DP members, led by committee ranking member Rep. Kim Byung-joo, said they would visit the site on Sep 28.

US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

Steel and aluminium remain at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired Jul 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff. Section 301 — launched Mar 11, 2026 against 16 trading partners including South Korea — is now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

TARIFFS

EXPIRED

Section 122 surcharge lapsed Jul 24; Section 301 now the primary tariff vehicle; sector 232 rates still in force.

WATCH THIS DATE
next trigger: Section 301 determination — pending, no fixed date

SECTOR RATES		
Steel & Aluminum	SECTION 232	50%
Copper	SECTION 232	50%
Automobiles & Auto Parts	SECTION 232	15%
Timber / Lumber / Wood Derivatives	SECTION 232	15%
Semiconductors (advanced logic)	SECTION 232 (PROCLAMATION 11002)	25%
Pharmaceuticals	SECTION 232	up to 15%
Civil Aircraft & Parts	US-KOREA DEAL EXEMPTION	0%
Generic Pharma / Precursors / Rare Natural Resources	ALIGNED PARTNERS LIST	0%

FULL TRADE REFERENCE →

Investment ledger, pledge tracker and standing policy measures.

BUSINESS & ECONOMY

International flight passengers through South Korean airports up 10% in 2026 despite higher oil prices

The number of international passengers using South Korean airports rose 10 percent year-on-year in 2026 despite Brent crude averaging above \$100. The passenger recovery supports Korean Air's \$36.2B Boeing order and \$13.7B GE Aerospace engine contract announced in Oct 2025.

Korean Air

NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

JAPAN-KOREA · JAPAN-DEFENSE · 한겨레

Japan Self-Defense Forces plan to deploy offensive missiles reaching China's coast in joint US-Japan exercises

Japan's Self-Defense Forces will deploy offensive missiles capable of reaching China's coastline in upcoming joint US-Japan exercises, per 한겨레. The development has direct implications for Japan's expanding strike capability posture and for US-ROK-Japan trilateral burden-sharing dynamics.

CHINA-KOREA · CHINA-DIPLOMATIC · 한겨레

US and China agree to operate 'Super Intelligence Dialogue' mechanism at Washington summit

US President Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping agreed at their Washington summit to establish a 'Super Intelligence (SI) dialogue' mechanism, per 한겨레, as Xi concluded his first US visit in 11 years. The US-China trade truce and AI governance framework directly affect South Korean technology firms and supply chains caught between the two powers.

PUBLIC SENTIMENT

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL

37%

▼ 1 pts vs 2026-09-11

Gallup Korea · September 18, 2026

42% since Aug 25-27 ↓ 37% across 4 readings

RULING
Democratic

39%

OPPOSITION
People Power

25%

INDEPENDENTS

26%

Gallup Korea Spotlight September 18, 2026

Presidential Approval — New Low: President Lee Jae-myung's approval fell to 37% this week, a new low, down from 38% the prior week and below his previous low of 42% recorded in August 2026.

Discourse: PPP lawmakers calling for National Assembly hearing on DMZ land-mine blast and undisclosed NK POW transfer; DP accuses opposition of politicizing national security — active political confrontation on both security issues during Chuseok holiday.

UPCOMING

Oct
1

ROK Armed Forces Day (국군의 날)

Also the anniversary of the ROK-US Mutual Defense Treaty, signed in Washington on 1 October 1953. Recent years have brought a parade through central Seoul and new systems shown publicly; alliance statements from both capitals usually land the same day.

Oct
3

National Foundation Day (개천절)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark, no Assembly business. Expect a thin domestic news flow and few primary-source releases.

Oct
9

Hangul Day (한글날)

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark. Falling within a week of 개천절, the two often bracket a slow stretch for government news.

Oct
10

Workers' Party founding day

The party was founded on this date in 1945. Decennial anniversaries have brought large Kim Il Sung Square parades and new systems shown in public for the first time; watch pre-event imagery for assembly.

• THE WIRE

DPRK

THE DIPLOMAT

North Korea's Ukraine POWs Are Now in South Korea. What Comes Next?

The Diplomat examines the unprecedented resettlement process facing both the ROK government and the two former North Korean soldiers transferred from Ukraine. ROK presidential office reiterated its humanitarian commitment to their treatment on Sep 26.

NK PRO

Kim Jong Un pushes propaganda overhaul as North Korea begins fall harvest

Kim presided over both the opening and closing ceremonies of a workshop for party propagandists this week while overseeing a missile test with his daughter Ju Ae; the pair later appeared together at a soccer match. NK Pro frames the week as unusually busy public activity after a period of relative silence.

TECHNOLOGY

KEIA

Energy for AI Leads South Korea's U.S. Investment Pipeline

The Korea Economic Institute of America identifies AI energy infrastructure as the leading sector in South Korea's US investment pipeline following the San Francisco AI Summit (Jul 24-25, 2026). The finding is consistent with the >\$500B NVIDIA-SK Group and \$10B NVIDIA+Brookfield-Naver commitments recorded in the investment ledger.

• ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

President Lee Jae-myung @Jaemyung_Lee

“At the Korea-Mexico Business Forum on the third day of Chuseok, I proposed three directions for cooperation: strengthening investment, advanced industries and supply chains; expanding cooperation into future industries and energy; and deepening cultural-creative industry exchange. Mexico is our largest Latin American trade and investment partner with bilateral trade reaching 28 trillion won. I also expressed hope that both countries will resume comprehensive trade agreement discussions as soon as possible.”

Context: The business forum statement aligns with the formal joint action plan adopted by Lee and the Mexican president on Sep 25, which covered defense, crude oil, and AI cooperation per prior Yonhap reporting.

[View on X →](#)

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.



Han Dong-hoon

Independent lawmaker (former PPP leader), press conference at Ministry of National Defense

“UNC Commander Xavier Brunson ordered a rapid investigation on Sep 21. On Sep 22, the UNC Military Armistice Commission visited the 25th Division requesting access to data, bodycam footage, and interviews with the injured — but our military refused. The Lee Jae-myung administration's Defense Ministry clearly planned not to conduct the field investigation before Sep 29.”

Analyst: Han stated at a Sep 26 press conference that the joint investigation date shifted from Sep 29 to Sep 27 only after public pressure; JCS has not confirmed this sequencing and has designated the investigation schedule classified.

[Source →](#)



Park Sung-jun

Democratic Party Chief Spokesperson

“The PPP's behavior of using national security as a tool for political strife has crossed a line. Handling the matter in a non-public manner to protect the defectors' safety and minimize unnecessary provocation is an entirely sensible measure.”

Analyst: Issued via written briefing on Sep 26 in response to PPP criticism over the undisclosed transfer of two North Korean POWs from Ukraine; DP frames non-disclosure as standard security protocol.

[Source →](#)

COMMENTARY

CSIS

Lips and Teeth? China, North Korea, and the Korean Peninsula

The CSIS Impossible State podcast episode examines the China-DPRK relationship in the context of evolving US-China dynamics following the Trump-Xi Washington summit. It addresses whether Beijing's tolerance of DPRK escalation serves or undermines Chinese interests, a question sharpened by concurrent IAEA reporting on Yongbyon expansion.

EAI

Implications of the Trump-Xi Washington Summit and the Extension of the US-China Trade Truce on South Korean Supply Chains

The East Asia Institute brief assesses the supply-chain implications for South Korea of the Trump-Xi summit outcomes. Korean firms face a 'frozen' technology competition environment where US-China coordination on AI and advanced chips may foreclose market opportunities while tariff truce uncertainty persists.

North Korea building new warships simultaneously at Nampho (west) and Chongjin (east) shipyards since early July

Planet Labs satellite imagery analyzed by NK Pro shows large hull sections being staged and assembled at the Nampho Shipyard on the west coast and the Chongjin Shipyard on the east coast since early July 2026, representing concurrent construction on both coasts. This dual-coast construction activity coincides with the Sep 8 commissioning of the destroyer Kang Kon at Wonsan. The Sinpo South Shipyard tracker entry is updated to reflect this expanded multi-site construction picture.

→ Sinpo South Shipyard

NK News / NK Pro ↗ · Korea Times ↗

ELEVATED ▲

Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

IAEA confirmed North Korea built a new uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon (Reuters/CNN, Sep 9-10, 2026), assessed capable of producing material for up to four additional warheads annually (조선일보). Russia dismissed the IAEA report at the Vienna session, citing lack of access. Apr 2026: Enrichment building expansion complete, new centrifuge hall operational. 5 MWe reactor and IRT-2000 both running. Thermal signatures consistent with increased plutonium/HEU production.

imagery as of 2026-09-10

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinpo South Shipyard

NK Pro satellite imagery (Sep 25) shows new warship construction begun at Chongjin Shipyard (east coast) and Nampho Shipyard (west coast) since early July — dual-coast concurrent construction. Hero Kim Kun Ok SLBM submarine exited drydock after 2+ years of fitting-out but still not operational as of May 2025. New submarine construction begun in separate bay.

imagery as of 2026-09-25

ACTIVITY ▲

Punggye-ri Nuclear Test Site

Nov 2025: ROK DIA assessed Tunnel No. 3 is test-ready and a nuclear test can be conducted at any time upon political decision. Site maintained at high readiness since mid-2024. Sep 9, 2016 fifth nuclear test 10-year anniversary fell three days ago; post-anniversary period historically carries elevated test risk. CNN/Yonhap reported Sep 18 that nearly 1,400 seismic events have been detected near the site since the 2017 test.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

ALERT ▲

Tumangang-Khasan (NK-Russia border)

Sep 8, 2026: The first road bridge over the Tumen River between North Korea and Russia was formally opened at a ceremony attended by Russian PM Mikhail Mishustin; the bridge is named after Soviet officer Yakov Novichenko. This constitutes a new permanent road link across the shared border, the first of its kind. NK News reporting confirms North Korea remains closed to private car travel via the bridge; crossings are limited to organized bus tours per the Association of Tour Operators of Russia (ATOR). NBC News analysis (Sep 15) frames the bridge alongside the near-complete Sinuiju-Dandong crossing as dual infrastructure bets by Pyongyang.

imagery as of 2026-09-15

ACTIVITY ▲**Sinuiju–Dandong (NK-China border)**

Sep 21, 2026: ROK Embassy in Beijing confirmed the cargo carried by heavy trucks crossing the new Yalu River bridge on Sep 17 consisted of air-conditioning units (HVAC equipment) destined for the customs building, indicating construction is roughly 70-80% complete. Embassy source said the bridge could open approximately one month after building completion following a trial period, with the NK-China diplomatic anniversary (Oct 6) cited as a possible opening date. DPRK national insignia already installed on the North Korean customs building.

imagery as of 2026-09-21

ACTIVITY ▲**Rason SEZ**

Sep 21-22, 2026: NK Pro satellite imagery analysis shows a likely Russian cargo vessel docked at Rason for the first time since May 2026 — a roughly four-month gap after near-continuous activity in 2024-2025. Nov 2025: Chinese businesspeople re-entry to Rason SEZ expanded. Coal exports through Rason at highest levels in years throughout 2025. Arms export berth also active.

imagery as of 2026-09-22

ACTIVITY ▲**Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)**

Jan 2026: Arms shipments slowed due to ice — one Russian vessel (likely Angara or Lady R) visited Rason, docked Jan 14 at arms export berth. Cargo routed to Vostochny. Since Sep 2023: 64 voyages by 4 vessels (Angara, Maria, Maya-1, Lady R) delivered ~15,800 containers (~4.2-5.8M munitions) from Rajin to Vostochny/Dunai. Road bridge now open Sep 8, 2026, providing first permanent road route to supplement existing rail. NK News satellite imagery (Sep 18) shows ongoing upgrades to DPRK urban warfare training facilities consistent with troops rotating back from Russia.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

4 other monitored sites: no new imagery in the last 30 days · oldest report 2025-09.

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